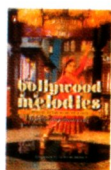


LIVING IN A SONG

The golden era of Hindi film music comes alive in this passionately nostalgic narrative by a Bollywood buff



BOLLYWOOD MELODIES: A HISTORY OF THE HINDI FILM SONG
by GANESH ANANTHARAMAN
Penguin
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 453

■ By Chandan Mitra

This is by a buff, for the buff. In an age where 20-something TV commentators believe history began the day they joined the profession, it is also a useful compendium for information-challenged experts who believe R.D. Burman is all there ever was to Hindi film music. However, for those who grew up in those heady days listening to Vividh Bharati, or remember times when 78-rpm shellac records were played on manually wound-up gramophones embossed with the ubiquitous HMV logo, Ganesh Anantharaman's book is pure ambrosia. It is a breathtaking trip down memory lane.

Anantharaman is not a mere chronicler. He has not pulled his punches about his likes and dislikes. For instance, he is extra-partial towards film songs based on classical Indian music and uses his extraordinary knowledge of ragas to impart a scholastic flavour to the narrative. He also cross-refers quite effectively. For example, he mentions the breezy Pankaj Mullick number *Chale pawan ki chaal* as a forerunner to O.P. Nayyar's extensive use of the hoof beat of tongas. His tribute to the early pioneers like Anil Biswas is particularly gratifying for many of them died unsung, sometimes in penury.

But Anantharaman's assessment of Shankar-Jaikishan is certain to generate a great deal of controversy. First, he insinuates Raj Kapoor hemmed in the duo's creativity with his own distinct ideas about music. If the songs of *Barsaat*, *Awara*, *Aah*, *Anari*, *Shree 420* and *Mera Naam Joker* are instances of curbed creativity, the definition of creativity itself may have to be revised!

Further, because of his dogmatism about raga-based numbers, Anantharaman makes a sweeping remark:

"Yaaahooo, screamed Shammi Kapoor on screen in *Jungle* bidding goodbye to melody in Hindi films for good measure." If that weren't enough, he proceeds to castigate the duo by saying "Ironically, they became the highest paid composers in the 1960s when their music reached its nadir in popular, if loud and unmusical numbers for Shammi Kapoor." If that is indeed so, why single out this duo? What about Nayyar (*Kashmir ki Kali*) or even Burman in *Teesri Manzil*?

However, Anantharaman must be complimented for his ability to highlight

although the scores of *Dil Deke Dekho*, *Lal Bangla*, *Honeymoon* and *Hawas* displayed flashes of genuine talent from filmdom's only female composer.

It is a trifle surprising, though, that the writer chose to devote a separate section on singers, remarkable primarily for an extended panegyric to Lata Mangeshkar. The singer can rarely be separated from the song's composer and hence, Anantharaman ends up repeating many observations in two sections. It might have been better to club composers and singers in a larger section and reserve a smaller one for lyri-



DANGER ZONE: The book insinuates Kapoor dictated composers' creativity

the best (not necessarily the most popular) compositions of music-directors as diverse as Khemchand Prakash, Naushad, Madan Mohan, S.D. Burman, Salil Choudhury, Roshan, Hemant Kumar, Ravi, Jaidev, Kalyanji-Anandji as well as the twin colossi of the '70s and '80s, Burman and Laxmikant-Pyarelal.

Personally, I am pained he did not think it fit to include a reference to the highly talented but commercially unsuccessful Iqbal Qureshi who gave his all for a C-grade Chandra Shekhar-Helen starrer, *Cha Cha Cha*. Similarly, Usha Khanna has been dismissed with a couple of passing references,

cists. Nevertheless, he does a competent job in summarising the works of poets (it would be an insult to call song writers of yore mere lyricists) like Shakeel Badayuni, Sahir Ludhianvi, Shailendra, Kaifi Azmi and (occasionally) Anand Bakshi. However, the writer clearly lacks the same mastery over poetry in comparison to his phenomenal knowledge of music. So he fails to pick out some of Kaifi's and Sahir's best works, sticking to listing the better known and obvious ones.

This volume is a rare treat for music lovers with an exhaustive index of over 1,500 songs. *Bollywood Melodies* is more than a historical narrative; the passion of its writer is infectious for the reader. ■